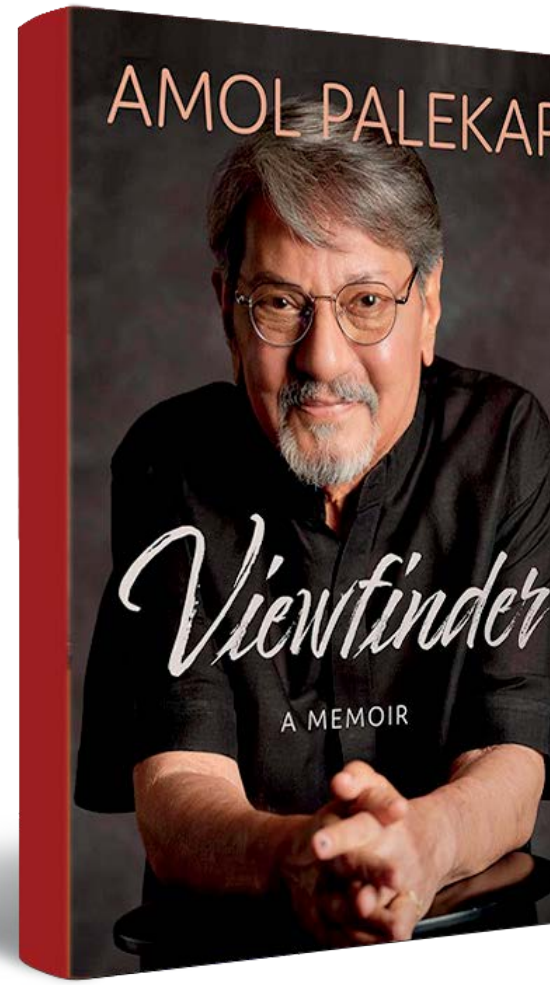
There's a heart-warming story behind the title of Amol Palekar's memoir, *Viewfinder*. When Palekar decided to direct his first film, Hrishikesh Mukherjee gave him a director's viewfinder which he himself had received from Bimal Roy before making his first film. It became a treasured possession for Palekar, imbued with symbolism. "How many great technicians, starting with Bimal da, must have used this priceless gift that I had received from Hrishi da," he writes. When monitors replaced viewfinders in film shooting, he passed it on to Roy's daughter, Rinki Bhattacharya.

For all the havoc it wreaked, the Covid-19 pandemic, with its enforced isolation, served as a creative well-spring for many, including Palekar. He had toyed with the idea of penning a memoir for nearly a decade. "Almost every publisher was after me. Many offers were that I would narrate and somebody would write, which I didn't like; because it is my choice of words and pace that makes my writing individualistic, and this must be there in a memoir," he says. Besides, he never had the time, being busy with painting, exhibitions and acting. Covid gave him the necessary solitude to "excavate" his thoughts, which he put down in longhand in Marathi, a process that took six months.

Then Palekar handed over the manuscript to wife Sandhya Gokhale to edit and curate. "Sandhya has this amazing capacity to look at my work with all the affection and yet with her critical faculties at their peak. That's why her opinion is the most important to me," he says. Sandhya took about seven months to finalise the Marathi version, and then did the English translation.

Viewfinder is a richly layered, cerebral memoir which moves back and forth in time, and offers a rare window into one of the finest minds in Indian cinema, in prose that is lyrical. For instance: "What do I do with the trivial, scattered details? Like the first



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***The Swinging '70s* is an information-packed homage to the 1970s Bollywood, which will give hours of reading pleasure to fans of that period**

Reading this book is more like spending leisurely time with a group of friends who grew up in the '70s (as I did), who love all things Hindi film (as I do), and who are now nostalgically teasing out their responses to that decade of film-making via their memories, experiences and the tools that hindsight has given them. Writers, journalists, academics, and practitioners like Vishal Bhardwaj, Subhash Ghai, Ketan Mehta...join hands to celebrate the decade that gave us (and this list is absolutely free of order or rationality): *Sholay*, *Deewar*, *Amar Akbar Anthony*, Zeenat, Parveen, Shabana-Smita-Naseer-Om, Bachchan, Benegal, R.D. Burman, Manmohan Desai, *Chupke Chupke*, *Garam Hawa*, 'Ram Prasad Sharma' and 'Basanti'. And the very best of Ajit.

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